



tournament come to an end in the Round of 32 due to a single sound wave. Trailing Portugal in added time, it found an equaliser via an own goal from a cross, but it was disallowed after a slight touch on the ball had rendered the play offside.

The touch was minute, causing no obvious deviation in the ball's trajectory, but it was detected through analysis of the waveform generated by a chip inside the ball, sparking debate about whether justice had really been served.

Similarly aggrieved was Egypt, which exited in a heated Round of 16 match against Argentina. The primary point of contention was a counterattacking goal that was ruled out due to a soft foul in the build-up.

Given that the goal required Egypt to go from one corner of the pitch to the other, a generous interpretation might argue that enough time had elapsed for Argentina to recover its defensive shape.

By the letter of the law, the correct decision was reached given

that the phase of play did not change from the foul to the goal. But once again, questions were raised about whether the severity of the decision was proportionate to the incident in question.

What's in a mistaken identity?

Another controversial and relatively unknown, until this World Cup, application of VAR was its ability to correct instances of "mistaken identity", where a decision could be overturned if the wrong player was penalised. An early example came in the group stage when Almiron was shown a yellow card after VAR found him to have simulated contact in an attempt to get USA's Tim Ream booked.

But it became even more prominent after Switzerland's quarterfinal against Argentina. With the match level in the closing stages, Swiss striker Breel Embolo was given his marching orders after a review showed that he had simulated contact.

It was yet another incident that undoubtedly changed the game and

Barest of margin: Igor Matanovic's faint touch, detected by Snickometer-style technology, put him offside and ruled out Croatia's stoppage-time equaliser, ending its World Cup campaign. GETTYIMAGES

raised questions about whether the ability to award a second yellow card should fall within the purview of VAR.

What should technology do?

Behind all of these incidents lies an understandable frustration among teams that have been knocked out. The FIFA World Cup is the biggest stage in football, and being eliminated by decisions that feel unjust, even if they are technically correct, will inevitably lead to complaints.

But beyond that lies a bigger question for football to answer. With VAR undoubtedly here to stay, the game must now decide how much technology is too much and, more importantly, how much authority it wants to give VAR over subjective decisions.